

spouse. It's a beautiful thing when everyone is pulling their own weight, not so beautiful when they aren't. I still remember a young woman from *Dragons' Den* whose family owned a jewelry store. She came onto the show looking for outside investors, but she had five uncles breathing down her neck, watching (and criticizing) her every move. The business was poorly managed because nobody in her family venture had clearly defined roles and everybody wanted to be in control. Remarkably, two Dragons made her an offer, but the company failed to thrive. It filed for bankruptcy barely a year after receiving funding, all because nobody knew how to build a proper team. It was a total disaster.

What about your family? Do you have the kind of strong bonds that would help you succeed in a family business? Your business doesn't have to be giant; it could be an online enterprise or a corner store. Maybe you taught your child how to sew, and now the two of you are thinking about selling pieces on Etsy or eBay. Or your partner has a side business selling antiques and you know you could create a dynamite website because you're a wiz with search engine optimization. If you have a dream of owning a small business, take your dream seriously and run some due diligence on your family unit. Who knows? Maybe your family has what it takes.

Money Mistake: *Your Business Hasn't Made Money After 36 Months*
The Fix: *It's a Hobby, Not a Business—Cut Your Losses and Move On*

Not everyone is cut out to be an entrepreneur. Even those who want to own their own business someday should think long and hard about involving their relatives. The most common mistake I see is when one family member gets really excited and launches something without adequate planning and preparation, pulling the rest of the family down into the vortex. You must be extremely careful and endlessly vigilant. If a business ruins your finances, it's not worth it, because it will probably ruin your family, too.

Set firm benchmarks and stick to them. Wicked Good Cupcakes didn't make money for their first year, and that's okay—most